ON a pitch dark night on January 7, 2024, the Indian Air Force (IAF) flew past a landmark achievement as an IAF pilot, after months of training, landed a C-130J Super Hercules tactical airlift/ transport aircraft at the Kargil airfield. With its unidirectional approach—surrounded by hills 14,000-15,000 feet high, with limited manoeuvrability and reduced engine efficiency—and short length of only 6,000 metres (as opposed to a normal one of 9,000 m), the airfield is a challenging place to land for aviators in daylight and good weather. To do so at night is notoriously tough. The feat is a testament to the superior skill and training of India's military aviators. "You are landing close to the LoC (just 12 km away) and at an ALG (advanced landing ground) that is very short and challenging because of the altitude and the surrounding mountains," says a senior Air Marshal at the IAF headquarters in New Delhi's Vayu Bhawan. The pilot has to get inside the valley, manoeuvre the aircraft and then land. "If it is cloudy, he doesn't even have visual contact on his approach till he gets beneath the clouds."



However, the significance of the landing goes far beyond than the deserved laurel of a milestone: it shows the increasing capability of the armed forces to operate all-weather operations with large transport aircraft through the day and night at such ALGs in close proximity to the Line of Control (LoC) with Pakistan and the Line of Actual Control (LAC) facing China. Couple the Kargil night landing with the fact that similar IAF aircraft regularly land at the world's highest airstrip at Daulat Beg Oldie near the LAC in eastern Ladakh, just 17 km away from the strategic Karakoram pass, and a clear message goes out to our two hostile neighbours—the Indian military is battle-ready and can deploy significant numbers of men and equipment quickly in response to any situation.

OPERATIONS LIKE THE NIGHT LANDING ARE INTEGRATED WITH TRAINING FOR THE IAF'S SPECIAL FORCES UNIT AND WILL HELP IN ITS DEPLOYMENT TO FORWARD AREAS

"Train pilots to push the aircraft to its fullest extent and, in case of a contingency, we can respond as close as possible to our border areas," says a senior IAF official. Indeed, the IAF says operations like the night landing are seamlessly integrated with the training mission for the IAF's elite Garud special forces unit and will help in sending it swiftly to forward areas.

However, 24-hour, all-weather landing and take-off at forward airfields is a work in progress and, with the emphasis on military readiness shifting from the Pakistan border to the LAC, the IAF has plans to upgrade all existing and upcoming airfields and air bases close to the China border. Speedy completion of the task will immeasurably enhance India's rapid deployment/ swift response capabilities, allowing movement of battalion-level strength with tanks and artillery near the LAC where, despite prolonged diplomatic and military talks, the situation remains challenging.

THE INFRASTRUCTURE WAR

Since the Chinese aggression at Galwan, in eastern Ladakh, in May 2020, the Chinese military has steadily built infrastructure near the LAC to accommodate higher numbers of men and materiel and has notably enhanced its airpower. The People's Liberation Army Air Force (PLAAF) has about 15 bases in the Tibetan Autonomous Region (TAR). In addition, China has upgraded air bases facing India, including Hotan, Kashgar, Gargunsa, Shigatse and Lhasa-Gonggar. Likewise, India's troop build-up has been accompanied by better infrastructure and telecommunications. It has also been modernising infrastructure at forward air bases and ALGs, including Thoise, Fukche, Nyoma and Daulat Beg Oldie in Ladakh as well as Pasighat, Mechuka, Walong, Tuting, Along and Ziro in Arunachal Pradesh on the Indo-China border. The IAF, the world's fourth largest air force in terms of personnel and aircraft, claims to be well poised, with around 25 airfields capable of launching operations against China.

In a response on airfield infrastructure in Parliament in December 2022, Ajay Bhatt, the minister of state for defence,